

All about me

- **BORN:** 1913
- **DIED:** 1996
- **NATIONALITY:** English
- **FACTOID:** I developed a new system for classifying ancient stone tools.
- **IN A NUTSHELL:** Born in London, England, I spent most of my life searching for human fossils and artefacts in Africa.

Hunting hominins

Mary had an amazing ability to find fossil **hominins** (ancient relatives of today's humans). In 1959, in the Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania, she found the **SKULL** of a human ancestor she nicknamed the "Nutcracker Man," since he had huge jaws and teeth. Later, she found the skull and hand of a species she called "**handy-man**," which was very closely related to modern humans.



"Nutcracker Man" lived in Africa around 1.75 million years ago.

By the way...

my obsession with early humans began when my dad took me to see cave paintings in France when I was 12.



The Laetoli fossilized footprints are more than 3.75 million years old.

A step ahead

Mary's most exciting discovery, in 1978, was a set of ancient **FOOTPRINTS** in Laetoli, Tanzania. They showed that humans began walking upright much **earlier** than scientists had thought. Mary is seen as one of the world's best **archaeologists**, scientists who specialize in unearthing the past. Her discoveries revealed a lot about where humans first came from.

Mary Leakey

The woman who found the **SKELETONS** in mankind's closet, and showed us where humans came from